

Training Children to Defeat Locks

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Abstract

A locksport master's project which involved organizing and guiding a group of children as they learned to defeat various locks, to provide useful security services to their community, and to share knowledge with the population of lock enthusiasts.

Overview

On January 7, 2025, I organized a group of 8 people – mostly 11- to 12-year-old children – who had shown an interest in locks. I ran classes for them through that month and into the next, starting with teaching them about some ancient locks and guiding them as they thought about how these locks might be attacked.

I made replicas of these locks for these lock enthusiasts to learn on. As a part of their training, with my guidance, they performed what seems to be the first documented non-destructive attack in history against a pin-tumbler lock of the ancient Egyptian style. As their skills developed, this group progressed to various modern locks as well, including residential and industrial types. They rekeyed locks. And they learned to detect improper uses and improper installations of locks that make them vulnerable to certain bypasses.

I provided an enlarged cutaway model of a modern pin-tumbler lock for them to train with, as well as normal-size locks of various types. Every member of the group learned to open at least four types of locks by some combination of impressioning, raking, single-pin picking, or use of a pick gun. They also mastered several bypass methods such as the use of under-the-door tools and celluloid cards. I made some 3D-printed white-belt and yellow-belt awards, which I granted to them as they achieved the requirements of those ranks.

Once they had learned so many things to look for in determining how well secured a building is, I made arrangements for this group to perform a complimentary physical-security assessment on behalf of the occupants of a building in the area. In the process of arranging this, I was able to show several adults that lockpicking enthusiasts are making a positive contribution to society. As a result, more of the community has become supportive of this group and of the sport of lockpicking, and more children are showing an interest in joining us.

Evidence

As evidence, I submit the following:

- Exhibit A – <https://www.gridscout.net/locksport/locksmithing101-slides.pdf>
Slides of my first presentation on pin-tumbler locks – which ended up lasting us for a few follow-up sessions beyond that first night.
- Exhibit B – <https://www.gridscout.net/locksport/egyptian-impressioning.pdf>
A report, from me and two of these children, on a few variants of the first publicly documented impressioning attack against ancient Egyptian pin-tumbler locks.
- Exhibit C – <https://youtu.be/ojocZivxhPY>
A video of me demonstrating the most refined of these impressioning attack variants.
- Exhibit D – <https://www.gridscout.net/locksport/redacted-physical-security-assessment.pdf>
A redacted report, from the group, of their first time performing the service of physical-security assessment.